



BUY, SELL, GIVE, RECEIVE

BetterBarter

The marketplace for one campus at a time — where **every counterparty is verified** and every handoff is confirmed in person.



PROBLEM

Students already trade with each other. Badly.

Fragmented channels

No one place to buy or sell within a university. It happens across Facebook Marketplace, WhatsApp groups, class GroupMees, eBay and thrift stores — so nobody can find anything and nothing accumulates.

No trust, no verification

Meeting a stranger from a public marketplace means handing over a phone number and often an address. The safety cost is why most students never list at all.

Wrong timing, wrong distance

A cheap item is thirty minutes away by subway. Sellers reach a general audience with no way to surface to the people already in the same four blocks.

So it goes in the skip

Move-out compresses a year of disposal into one week. What does not sell in time is dumped — and ten days later the next intake buys it new.

SOLUTION

A board that only your campus can see.

Verified community

A university email is the only door in, and it maps to a campus inside the database. Every person you deal with proved they belong to your school.

Safety by construction

First names only. Phone numbers, emails, social handles and room numbers cannot be sent — the message is refused. Meetups are public places on campus.

Four ways to move a thing

Give it, sell it, swap it, rent it out. Browse by category, filter by how far you are willing to walk, and see what has to be gone by Friday.

Then both sides confirm the handoff with a six-digit code split across the two phones — the thing that turns a marketplace into a dataset.

Deployed, hardened, and open source.

Marketplace

Category-first browsing, colour-coded by how the object moves. Coarse distance only — never a precise location. A "gone by" date on anything leaving with its owner.

Claim and chat

Claiming opens a thread and holds the item for three hours, so two people are not walking to the same lobby. Realtime, with contact details blocked at the point of sending.

Confirmed handoff

Six digits, three on each phone. Joining them completes the handoff for both sides at once and is the only thing that counts a reuse event.

0

Contact details exchanged
enforced, not requested

3h

Hold on a claim

7d

Freshness check
stale listings pause themselves

1

Campus per board
enforced in Postgres

The institution pays. The students never do.

Campus licence · \$15k a year

core

Anchored on a cost the university already carries — move-out hauling, plus the circularity reporting it must produce anyway. It buys object-level, auditable reuse data that no collection programme can produce.

Verified-audience placements

later

Local businesses reaching a genuinely verified campus audience. Additional revenue, excluded from every projection here.

Boosted listings · \$2

A seller can pay to bump a listing to the top. Small, honest, and paid before anyone has your number.

Why no cut of the handoff

Taking a percentage would mean holding money, adjudicating disputes, and giving both sides a reason to settle off-platform. It would also corrupt the data that is the product.

Two ways of counting, both from published figures.

	LICENCE REVENUE	OBJECTS MOVED	DERIVATION
TAM	≈\$58M / yr	≈46M / yr	3,896 US degree-granting institutions (NCES) × \$15k · 15.4M undergraduates × 3 objects
SAM	≈\$18M / yr	≈14M / yr	~1,200 residential four-year campuses where move-out density makes it work
SOM · year 3	≈\$375k / yr	≈300,000	25 licensed campuses — roughly 2% of the serviceable set

Target audience: any verified university email. Beachhead is Columbia — 30,000+ students across Morningside, with the highest-density residential move-out in the city.

Why now: universities are under binding waste-reduction targets (Columbia's Plan 2030 among them) and have no object-level data to report against them.

COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE

Everyone else is either open to the world, or a bin.

WHO	WHAT IT IS	WHERE IT FAILS A STUDENT
Facebook Marketplace	Open marketplace, city-wide	Unverified strangers, phone numbers exchanged, travel across the city
WhatsApp / GroupMe	Class and hall group chats	No search, no history, no reputation — a listing scrolls away in an hour
Give + Go Green	Staffed campus collection at check-out	Catches what is left at the end; nothing moves student-to-student before the pile forms
Depop / Vinted	Peer resale, shipped	Packaging and postage on a \$10 desk lamp — the emissions cancel the point
BetterBarter	One verified campus, meet in a lobby	Complementary to collection; the only one that produces auditable reuse data

The moat is not the board — a board is a weekend. It is the verified graph plus a confirmation a single person cannot fake, which is what makes the data worth licensing.

Distribution runs through institutions, not advertising.

1 • Land one campus

Columbia, at the two moments that matter: orientation, when a thousand rooms are empty and need filling, and move-out, when they all have to be cleared. Housing, EcoReps and sustainability offices already own both moments and already have the mailing lists.

2 • Prove the number

One pilot with verified handoff data a sustainability office can put in a report. That report is the sales collateral for every campus after it — nobody else can hand them one.

3 • Let campuses open themselves

A university email domain maps to a campus server-side, from a registry of 7,328 academic domains. A new school's board exists the moment its first student signs in. No waiting list, no launch, no code to write.

Small numbers, and the assumptions printed next to them.

YEAR	LICENSED CAMPUSES	REVENUE	WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE
1	1 pilot, unpaid	\$0	A Columbia pilot runs through the 2027 move-out and produces a defensible number
2	5	\$75k	That report converts four more campuses in the same conference
3	25	\$375k	~2% of the 1,200 serviceable campuses, at \$15k each

What we are asking for

Not capital yet. A pilot campus, an introduction to a housing or sustainability office, and people willing to attack the displacement assumption in the impact model.

What it costs to run today

Effectively nothing — a free-tier database and static hosting. The first real costs are daily backups and a support inbox, both of which arrive with the first pilot.

The only wrong answer is the dumpster.

Live today at betterbarter.vercel.app. Open source, with the impact model published in full so you can check the arithmetic before you believe it.

Agung Nugroho · mn3265@columbia.edu

Tessa Wong · tw3119@columbia.edu

github.com/mn3265-commits/betterbarter